You can use pre-cooked chestnuts for this soup from Piedmont, Italy, but fresh ones have a more velvety texture (although you should allow time for peeling.)

piedmont chestnut soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 5 MINS USING COOKED CHESTNUTS **COOK** 1 HR 55 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS BEFORE RICE IS ADDED

8oz (225g) fresh chestnuts or
6oz (180g) cooked peeled chestnuts
2 sprigs thyme
1 bay leaf
1¼ quarts (1¼ liters) chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2oz (60g) risotto rice
2 tbsp butter
1¼ cups milk
a little truffle oil, to serve

1 If using fresh chestnuts, score each one with a small sharp knife (see below), then put half a dozen at a time into a microwaveproof bowl. Cover tightly with plastic wrap and cook on High for 20–30 seconds or until the skins have split, then peel. Put the peeled chestnuts in a pan with the herbs, stock, and a little salt and freshly ground black pepper, bring to a boil, then simmer for 1½ hours.

2 Add the rice and simmer for 10 minutes. Stir in the butter and the milk and simmer for a final 10 minutes. Remove the bay leaf and thyme, taste, and adjust the seasonings, if necessary. Serve with a few drops of truffle oil in each bowlful to turn this peasant soup into a major treat.

PEELING FRESH CHESTNUTS



Score a deep cross in the skin of each chestnut with a knife, to keep it from exploding as it cooks.



After cooking, the shells will have split. Peel off the outer and inner skin with your fingers.